

A different kind of mac and cheese

Roasted vegetables, three cheeses—including my favorite, smoked mozzarella—and a hazelnut and macadamia topping make this version of mac and cheese a bit different—and more **sophisticated**. Gemelli, meaning “twins” in Italian, is a dense and chewy pasta shaped like two strands of spaghetti twisted together. If you can’t find gemelli, look for radiatore, which is Italian for “little radiators,” and that’s exactly what they look like.

½ pound carrots, peeled and cut into thin sticks 2 inches [5cm] long [250g]

2 tablespoons olive oil

1 large red bell pepper, cut into strips 2 to 3 inches [5 to 8cm] long

1 small onion, thinly sliced

Salt and freshly ground pepper

4 ounces hazelnuts [125g]

4 ounces macadamia nuts [125g]

4 ounces sharp Cheddar cheese, shredded [125g]

4 ounces smoked mozzarella, shredded [125g]

4 ounces goat cheese, crumbled [125g]

1 pound gemelli [500g]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

6 scallions, thinly sliced on the diagonal, for garnish

1. Preheat the oven to 425°F [220°C]. In a medium bowl, **toss** the carrots with 1 tablespoon of the olive oil to coat lightly. Spread out on a baking sheet and roast for 15 minutes.
2. Toss the bell pepper strips and onion slices with the remaining olive oil in the same bowl to coat lightly. **Add** the peppers and onions to the carrots on the baking sheet and return to the oven for another 20 minutes. Ideally, the carrots should be golden brown, the onions soft and lightly browned, and the pepper soft, with a few lightly blackened edges. Season the roasted vegetables with salt and pepper and set aside.

3. In a large dry skillet, **toast** the hazelnuts and macadamias over medium heat, shaking the pan often to prevent burning, until fragrant and lightly browned, 3 to 5 minutes. Let cool slightly, then pulse the toasted nuts in a food processor until coarsely chopped.
4. **Toss** together all the cheeses and set aside.
5. Bring at least 4 quarts [4L] salted water to a vigorous boil. Add the pasta and stir immediately and often until the water returns to a boil. **Cook** until the pasta is al dente (slightly resistant to the bite), then drain it quickly in a ready colander. Shake out the water.
6. Pour the hot pasta into a large bowl and immediately add the cheeses and roasted vegetables. Toss to mix thoroughly. **Season** with salt and pepper to taste. Serve each portion hot, topped with the chopped nuts and sliced scallions.

SERVES 4 TO 6

